

The Polish Vistula Legion
The Poles were especially enthusiastic in their support for Napoleon as he liberated many of them from Russian and Austrian rule. The Vistula Legion fought in the Peninsular War and marched with the Grande Armée to Moscow.



THE ARTILLERY

Even in the pre-Revolutionary army, the French artillery was a technocracy in which men of ability were able to rise through their own merits. Napoleon's innovations were primarily tactical. He concentrated cannon in large batteries at decisive points on the battlefield and deployed horse artillery aggressively in forward positions.

Napoleonic artillery was very professional. A team of gunners could fire a 12-pounder cannon three times a minute. They were supported by teamsters who looked after the horses and carriages, and by artisans who maintained and repaired equipment. Firing the guns was tough work. After each shot the crew had to run the cannon back, load, and re-aim. Their arms and faces quickly became black with powder, while targets were often obscured by thick smoke. At the battle of Wagram in 1809, French artillery fired 96,000 cannonballs in two days. The horse artillery was no less impressive: galloping into enemy range, they were able to detach their guns, sight, and fire in under a minute.

The quality of artillery personnel remained high, even though officer training time was cut dramatically from 1807. By 1814, however, there were chronic shortages of both powder and shot. Napoleon never achieved the ratio of five cannon to every thousand soldiers he thought optimal.

THE IMPERIAL GUARD

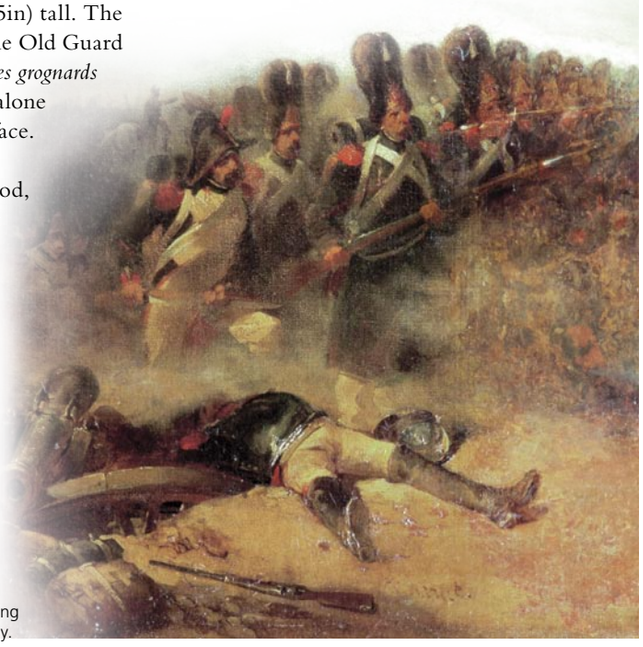
Originally formed as the Consular Guard in 1799 and renamed in 1804, the Imperial Guard was at first a relatively small force serving as Napoleon's personal bodyguard. In 1804 it consisted of some 5,000 infantry, 2,000 cavalry, and an artillery contingent. By 1812, it had swelled into a large army corps with over 100,000 soldiers.



Imperial eagle
The Napoleonic eagle and imperial crown figured prominently on the uniforms and kit of all branches of the Imperial Guard.

At the core of the Imperial Guard were the hand-picked veterans of the Old Guard. To join this elite, a soldier needed to have served in at least two campaigns, have a minimum of four years service, and be at least 1.65m (5ft 5in) tall. The senior infantry regiment within the Old Guard were the Grenadiers, nicknamed *les grognards* ("the grumblers") – because they alone dared complain to the Emperor's face. All the Imperial Guard enjoyed privileges. They had better pay, food, equipment, and medical treatment than line infantry. Guard ranks rated one step above their line equivalent – so a corporal in the Guards was equivalent to an ordinary sergeant. The Middle Guard, selected between 1806 and 1809, had a high percentage of non-French troops and never equalled the Old Guard in status. The Young Guard, recruited from the best of each year's intake of conscripts from 1809, barely constituted an elite force at all.

Always in full dress uniform on campaign, the Guards were an imposing sight, especially the Grenadiers in their tall bearskins. Napoleon was, however, reluctant to commit his Old Guard to battle, keeping them as his last reserve. They were notably held back from the slaughter at Borodino in 1812, earning them the ironic nickname "the immortals". When the Old Guard broke in the face of British and Dutch volleys at the battle of Waterloo in 1815, Napoleon was finished.



The Guard at Waterloo
As word spread that the Imperial Guard had been forced to retreat, the news was a crushing blow to morale in the rest of the French army.